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Phil Wilson

Phil Wilson has distinguished himself in the world of jazz as a trombonist, arranger, and celebrated educator at the Berklee School of Music.

Phil was interviewed via Zoom on September 27, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very, very pleased to have Mr. Phil Wilson with me today, trombonist, jazz educator, composer, and arranger. Thanks for your time.

PW: Oh it's a pleasure to be here, Monk. Thank you for asking me.

MR: I want to start out with a quote from you in a document that I saw, and in it you were talking about Berklee and your career, and it said, "I'm thankful to the Berklee family for the opportunity I've had to earn a living doing what I should be doing for forty years." So I'm wondering if you can cast your memory way back, did you have a time when you were young that you decided what you should be doing? When did you feel that you could and should be making a living in music?

PW: When did you think I could get away with it I think is what you're saying. It goes really way back. If we were to — I was born in a dormitory that looked more like a mansion with the Belmont Hill School in Belmont, Massachusetts, and there was a piano in a kind of a garden room at one end of the building which had an old upright piano. And everybody was out of the house. Again, there's no musicians in my family. We were busy trying to make the Belmont Hills School come alive. Back in those days that school had 152 students and 24 that graduated doing grades 7 through 12. And my dad married the headmaster's daughter, who had three beautiful young ladies, and then I was an afterthought really, coming another seven years later. So they were really busy trying to make this school work in those days. And not unlike the basic group that was in the original Berklee School of Music later on. Because it's the same idea of building and trying to make it work and still pay salaries of the teachers it's a whole other thing as you well know. So that upright piano in the back, if everybody was out of the house I would get into that room and start screwing around you know. And pretty soon I started playing hymns that I heard in the church which was in Boston. The family went down every Sunday unless I stayed home to cook with my father which was a wonderful thing. So I knew that what I was playing, you know triads, was good. There's that thing and feeling that goes up your back you know, when something really thrills you. It can be anything but when something's like — I was four years old at the time, if not younger.

MR: Did you have any idea if you were playing the hymns discovering them in the key that that you heard them in?

PW: No. I was only playing on the white keys.

MR: White keys, right.

PW: A minor was a big one.

MR: Exactly.

PW: Right?

MR: I still just play on the white keys.

PW: After a while I started realizing that hey, I don't have to keep playing the same stuff, I started doing my own stuff. And that same, every time something really happened, you know, that really was a thrill, that thing would go up my back and and I'd say you know that's good. And there's nobody in the building except for one person on the third floor of this building that we called — where I was from ages zero to five there was eight boys were living on the eighth floor — day students from Monday through Friday — and they had a faculty member who loved jazz, particularly Louis Armstrong's Hot 5 and, you know, Sidney Bechet and that whole thing. And so I must have heard some of that because later on I began to, especially when I heard Louis Armstrong at Symphony Hall with Jack Teagarden and Barney Bigard and that beautiful band he had played that album with which I managed to get a hold of a copy. And that made — Louis was a huge influence. And there was also another thing going on at Belmont with my mother and father working quite hard trying to keep my three sisters alive and well, they were also trying to keep that school working. So I was really largely raised by three women of color: Willie Sims who was in our family for almost 40 years looking after my grandmother who had to be in bed every night at 7:00 period with a heart ailment you know. So Willie Sims really took care of my grandmother but during the day my parents were not around, my sisters were at school somewhere, and so I really was on my own really and these three wonderful women, over a period of five years, starting at the age of zero, were around me giving me lots of love. And I loved those women. And it never occurred to me, even later in life until I grew up you know, I was pretty naive. Colored people, different skin colors and things like that, that was happening to me from the beginning of my life and I never thought anything of it. What reason is there?

MR: Do you recall the first time, or a significant time when you witnessed segregation or racial attitudes that were mysterious to you?

PW: I mean yes, but only in those days no. I was really colorblind. But then when I first went with the Dorsey band, which was — this was a hell of a lot later — this would be when I was 20 I went with the Dorsey band and I was going to meet them in Shreveport, Louisiana. And I took the milk plane around to every milk stop around the country to get to Shreveport. Oh my God, and I'd never flown before and I wasn't ready for it, believe me. No it was not what I wanted, what I wanted to be doing? But I got out in Shreveport

and it was the first time you had segregated water, separated bathrooms, separated restaurants. I'd never ever seen that. And we toured the rest of the summer around the south. Back then the Dorsey band was fully booked because the ballrooms in the country were still — they still existed for Christ's sake. So, and the Dorseys, you've got to remember in 1940 the Dorsey name was as big as Elvis Presley in terms of the lasting — they had legs, they had legs.

MR: Yeah.

PW: So every night we played a dance somewhere and of course both Tommy and Jimmy at that point had died. Jimmy was a month before I joined the band. He died of smoking, you know cancer, same year [inaudible] Tommy died 18 months before of throwing up in his sleep after taking Seconal and all that sort of stuff. So we were billed as the Jimmy Dorsey Band but still Lee Castaldo was the leader at the time and Lee was a favorite of the Dorseys, both of them, because Tommy loved his playing and so did Jimmy for that matter, but Tommy had a small band within the band called the Clambake Seven and he loved to have Lee playing the lead part. But the problem is he couldn't put him in the section because he couldn't read. And so he sent him to take lessons with his father, who taught both Jimmy and Tommy. And so Lee became like a third Dorsey brother for about a year or so until he could read adequately so he could read Tommy's book. And later on, after Tommy and Jimmy died and I joined the band I actually met the mother — amazingly strong woman, my God.

MR: Did the anticipation of joining a well-known big band equal the experience when you got with the band then you went on the road on a bus every day, did it get to be the same? Did it get to be this realization that this life is not necessarily what I thought it would be?

PW: No I don't think so. It was pretty much what I expected it to be. But after a while you start listening to some of the cadenzas I was playing in Woody's band where "Give Me the Simple Life" began to appear an awful lot.

MR: I see. Oh that's funny.

PW: It is indeed. You know the tape by any chance that I did, "Lonesome Old Town" that was broadcast from England with Woody's band?

MR: I don't think I've heard that.

PW: Go down to the cadenzas, you're going to hear a nice version of "Give Me the Simple Life."

MR: And what did your parents think of our son Phil the big band trombonist?

PW: I was the black sheep of the family for a while, are you kidding? My family was a loving family, God love them, I know they're going to probably see this and I love you all forever and you know it. But at that time you've got to remember that everybody is from the Ivy League, dad graduated from Harvard and married the headmaster's daughter at

Belmont Hill, which today is a thriving school just like Berklee is a thriving school. But of course that's two different countries totally. But the — oh now man I'm sorry —

MR: Well I'm wondering if what I'll call the jazz life, the day to day, the night to night — was it a culture shock to go from your upbringing into the jazz life?

PW: Yes of course. Huge. But on the other hand there weren't many other things I really felt I was much good at you know? Music has always been part of my life. Even I've got a mild case of dyslexia, I'm not a fast reader. I'm not one of these guys who can walk in and do about four or five commercials and cash in on the royalties you know. I'd love to be — I did do some of that and I actually did play also, I was first call in Boston for 38 years doing the shows. But while everybody else is playing poker waiting for the show to begin I was reading the music just to look out for what I needed to look out for. I'd take the book home. So I really took care of business with that stuff. But I'm also, when you say I'm a poor reader that's not really the truth. I'm a damn good reader as a matter of fact, I'm just painfully slow. Period.

MR: Okay.

PW: I do have those moments that are pretty much legendary. I do occasionally change a digit around and you know, the annoying things that do come along with dyslexia. And of course now I'm 86 years old and I've got a menu of diseases going on in this old body of mine so you know it seems very unimportant.

MR: I was reading *Woody Herman Chronicle of the Herds* book and there was an interesting anecdote from you talking about in two days, one day you're playing for Governor Faubus of Arkansas and the next night you're playing in Harlem.

PW: Yep.

MR: Can you tell me a little bit about that?

PW: Yes. We went down, wasn't that Governor Faubus —

MR: Yes. Alabama.

PW: Alabama. Well we started playing in the beginning, people just coming into the room, right? [sings] "It was just one of those things," sounds like a general business band except it was written by Ralph Burns. But we were getting away with it only everything's in two, right? And the second set comes by and we're still in two — we take a break, we come back and we're in two. By now these old politicians and whatever they are, are getting a little juiced and they're feeling no pain. Then we go to four. Now when we went to Harlem, two days later, we just started right out in four. We didn't mess around.

MR: Didn't mess around. I'd like to ask you, because some people who might watch this may not know what are you talking about, in two and in four. And do you have memories of, now I'm thinking of you at Berklee and starting off the year and you've got the Dues

Band or a big band and explaining the difference in two or in four to the bassist and the drummer. How did you do that?

PW: By playing it. I actually had a small set of drums back when I was twelve years old that somebody left in a dormitory up at Phillips Exeter where we moved to after, at age six, and this would be six through eighteen dad was running the freshman dorm, that means I had 74 boys living with me in this Dunbar Hall. And it was like living in a Holiday Inn with a dining room to seat 250 people every morning at 7, every afternoon around 12:30 and every night around 6 and that was right next our living room of course. We had adjourned walls so that doesn't make for a nice cozy living room. Anyways at Exeter the — no I'm not going to be able to finish that story.

MR: Well you were talking about — I was wondering how you taught the bassist and the drummer the —

PW: Two to four.

MR: Yes. Two to four.

PW: Right. I had a set of drums. I used to play them when I was twelve years old to Buddy Rich doing "Well Git It" in Tommy Dorsey's band. Things like that. And it was a — Exeter's a rich boy's school, come on. And boys leave stuff behind. And I'm a faculty brat, right for Phillips Exeter. I mean I'm growing up and running around and still not running my own show basically. And a boy left in the basement of Dunbar it was a full set of drums but it was not what we would think of playing in today's rock band, it was just a bass drum and a high hat and so actually I got to be a pretty good drummer to be able to figure out time feels and so if somebody was trying to [scats] there's a nice two but if you happen to move just a little bit faster than that you can go [scats] there's four [scats]. You know what I mean? You can just kind of give a little demonstration of what two feels like as against four in that manner. You could also go into marching bands and things like that, but I don't care for that so much. At one point at Phillips Exeter I ran my first big band at the age of — oh God I don't know, 16, 17, 18 — a 72 piece marching band for the football game at Phillips Exeter. And I used to try to do Glenn Miller's "St. Louis Blues."

MR: "St. Louis Blues" march. Yes, I used to love that.

PW: Yeah. And I finally, after about three years I got them so they could play it so you could recognize the melody.

MR: When I think of you young men on the bus I guess there are some stories about Woody Herman and the bus trips.

PW: Yep.

MR: What did you do on the bus to pass the time? This was well before people could stare at their phones all day or well before having a disc player. How did you pass the time?

PW: Very, very comfortably in a way. I mean I'm — 18, 19, 20 I went out with the Dorseys at 20 and basically I stayed on the road until I left Woody's band in '67? It can't be that long. I must be exaggerating. But still we're talking the Dorsey band, Al Belletto's group for half a year going into the army, the navy NORAD band — North American Air Defense Command — and that's where I learned all my technique I know about how to microphone etcetera, etcetera. I learned how to get my own sound. I recorded all these records for NORAD for two years out in Hollywood. We recorded two months of the year for two years. And I got to work on my arranging and composition and having it played on a daily basis. I learned to solo over, and write my own charts and things like that. They were not world leaders but they sure did help me learn my craft.

MR: Let me ask you some more about that. I may be a bit like you with arranging.

PW: I think so.

MR: Yeah. I never had books, I mostly absorbed what I was hearing from big bands and —

PW: Me too.

MR: And tried to make it, you know I would sit at the piano and say well if the saxes are doing this then maybe the trombones could do that and trial and error.

PW: Can I — I've got to tell you, this is a true story now. When we were in Exeter in this big dorm that my dad — my room was on the third floor of our apartment and the piano was on the first floor. And I'm listening to Jazz at the Philharmonic Volume 9 or 10, and in it Hank Jones is playing the piano and Bill Harris is playing the trombone and Dizzy you know and it's a ten inch you know. And in the middle of I think it was Bill Harris's solo Hank Jones hits a D/C7, in other words the upper structure triad, right? And I said, "Oh man." I mean he hits it and then moves on in the bridge of "Perdido" I think it was, right?

MR: Yes.

PW: And I said oh I love the sound of that chord. I wanted to know what that chord was. So I ran down two flights of stairs to the piano and started — I wish I had a piano here to demonstrate because it was funny. No. No. No. No. So I'd run up two flights of stairs and put it on, a 78 you know — it was not a — no that was an LP a 10 inch. And so finally this went on for over two weeks, up and down. I'm going to find that mother you know. And so finally — oh no, I took a red pencil and when it hit on the LP the C7 sharp 11 I marked it with red you know so I could just drop the needle on it. I did get it after two weeks. I told Hank Jones that years later when he was at some festival. He got a good laugh out of it.

MR: That is some paying of dues right there.

PW: No kidding.

MR: I always remember the feeling, usually good, sometimes not — when you toil over things and you're writing by pencil and you have to copy your own parts and then you finally get to hear it. I'm wondering if you got that feeling up your back.

PW: You better believe it. I do all the time. Yup. I'm getting to be one hell of a piano player now because you know later in life in 2014 I came down with lymphoma — B cell cancer. Non-Hodgkins you see. And that pretty much — it was the glands right here. And that really took the end of my trombone career. Because the radiation part of the chemotherapy and then I developed pneumonia for nine painful days and then I had a full month of radiation right in here. Five days a week at noon. And the residue from the radioaction from trying to get the cancer spilled over to the base of the tongue and boy that was the end of my fast tonguing at all — being able to get around the horn. Nobody would want to hear me play you know.

MR: What was it like, going back to Woody Herman for a moment — what was it like to follow Bill Harris and play tunes that featured him and now they feature you.

PW: I loved Bill Harris and I was hugely influenced by him. When I was in high school I had a band at Phillips Exeter, believe it or not, playing all the charts I wanted to play. And I wrote out [scats] "Everywhere," which was a big feature for Bill Harris, 1946 Carnegie Hall concert [scats] and the beautiful ending and all this sort of thing. He had a sound that was as luscious, Bill Harris — Bill Harris — Bill Watrous years later but he wasn't at obviously the same level playing the horn. He was more by the seat of his pants, so was Bill actually but he had had a little more experience.

MR: He had a bigger seat.

PW: Right. But Bill — "Bijou" was the one that Woody kept having me play. And I really didn't care for doing that. Listen, Woody Herman was perhaps one of the biggest influences in my life as a musician and as a person. He was special. I didn't like playing "Bijou" because it was Bill Harris's piece and I had "Lonesome Old Town." You know? So I didn't need to do that, and I didn't mean to dishonor in a sense Bill Harris. And then came a surprise. There's an album, a big 10 inch, 12 inch LP "Woody's Goodies." When Columbia Records took Woody Herman's band, the one we were with, we should talk about that a little bit more. There's an interesting story there. When Woody changed record labels from Phillips to Columbia in 1945 we did one, I did one, I performed there with him "My Kind of Broadway" and boy the band was cooking. It was really — that was about the peak of the band. Jake had left, Jake Hanna.

MR: Jake Hanna. Um huh.

PW: And Ronnie Zito came in, took his place. He did a great job but he was not a Jake Hanna you know. He learned actually. We did an Ed Sullivan Show with him playing my favorite [scats].

MR: "My Favorite Things."

PW: Yeah. We did that live on the Ed Sullivan Show and they set us up in a straight line about nine to ten feet above Nat Pierce piano, Ronnie Zito drums, and Charlie "The Arm" bass, who always played acoustic without an amp. Yeah. You know it. And it worked you know.

MR: I was anticipating a train wreck actually.

PW: It wasn't. Haven't you ever seen that video? You ought to check it out because I mean Chase and the five trumpets, three trombones you know, four saxophones up there and they — somebody had the smart idea, wouldn't it be fun to match the early days of Woody Herman's '62 band when we played The Metropole in New York, the corner of Seventh and Broadway I think it was, something like that. 48th Street. It was the corner of 48th and Broadway. And every night, this is what put us on the map because they had a picture made up of us and put it on the top of a *Billboard* issue, on the front page, because it was unheard of. The bar was 75 feet long. People had an open door, open, wide open, I mean really wide — you could park the car in the door. And people coming by the place could just walk in and walk out. I mean it was always open, right at the corner of Broadway and 48th so you know, it was always packed. And the bar went 48 — 75 feet up here is the band — the saxophones close to the door, then they run into Nat Pierce's piano and this is right behind the bar. And right at this point four saxophones and then you've got to have a piano and you couldn't put — it didn't fit on the just half the bar so it had to cover the full bar, so all the bartenders if they wanted to go from one end to the other they had to bow their head way, way down. It was unbelievable. But that was the stage. Also that was where Woody could do his act and Charlie "The Arm" — it was four saxophones, Charlie "The Arm," and then this thing over the bar right, with the drums and the piano and Woody. And then five trumpets over here and the three trombones way down there. Holy shit! And I was — you know I was a regular feature, I was blessed with that. And every time I had to play a solo I had to walk up in front of five trumpets to get to the microphone.

MR: It was a very narrow stage, wasn't it?

PW: Yes.

MR: Yes. Because the gentleman who started this whole project, the Hamilton graduate, talked about going there. The band would be in a straight line and boy, you have to listen really hard and listen in a different fashion.

PW: Yeah. And you better know it. It was a different fashion. And the opposite side of the room, it was a long room, not terribly wide okay? So the far — opposite the stage over there was a wall, ceiling to floor mirror. So that we could watch Jake Hanna's hi-hat. You know what I mean?

MR: I do.

PW: And that would keep it together. And that's exactly what we did. And during the third set, and the third set would usually go on around 2:30 in the morning. We started at 10. And when we'd get around to the third set every once in a while Jake, who had a sharp sense of humor, would start playing on one and three instead of two and four. And it made some interesting blips.

MR: Yeah. Instead of sight reading you were sight playing.

PW: Right. Yup.

MR: What finally prompted you to consider leaving that life and entering what was very early jazz academia?

PW: Right. Right you are. I wanted to raise a family. I mean I am the boy who came from academia in the first place. I never left academia. So that in a sense was always comfortable for me. I was always — I love people, period. I wanted to raise a family and make a living as a jazz trombone player and thanks to "Lonesome Old Town" I had a reputation all over the world. And I never got a degree myself, much to the discernment of my father, but I did get some honorary degrees a little later in life. So that made — the old man and I ended up good friends. So I have a wonderful family though. I think one of the most important things anybody could have is a family, a loving family too. And my wife Pat is a pianist from Indiana and I had to go through a divorce to get to some — really somebody I could live with and we'll be married — we were married 55 years.

MR: Congratulations.

PW: Yeah, yeah. And you could see, you just met my daughter, who is now 52 and she has seen us through the pandemic. You just don't have daughters like that. She always — oh what do you call it — archivist. And she's one hell of an archivist.

MR: Is the atmosphere at Berklee more like a family? Were you, I'm trying to get this idea about the academic level. Was it less about testing and goals than it was about just learning to play gigs?

PW: You know what made Berklee, to me, was the humanity of the faculty in 1965, '66, actually go back to '55. I go back a whole lot more years. But when I went to the New England Conservatory in 1955, jazz was a dirty word. It was the popular department and there were a few of us, like Roger Kellaway, the great pianist, and Freddie Buda, the percussionist for the Pops, great drummer, and myself and a few others, Al Nathan, were into jazz and we just were not interested in going immediately into the symphony. That was their thing. If you were going in for the symphony you were in the right place. But if you were a jazzer you were in the wrong place at that time. It has changed so please forgive me, it's turned out to be different, a fine top-of-the-line school that it should have always been as far as I'm concerned. But now here comes that faculty member down at

284 Newbury Street, it's a brown house — that's the Berklee School of Music and there's no degree given out. You can get a diploma. And all of a sudden you have teachers like Lennie Johnson — Lennie Johnson was a lead trumpet player you probably never heard of, but when Cat Anderson got shall we say, took a vacation to get his head back together, Lennie Johnson went out and covered for him for six weeks. And this was a regular happening over and over. So that in itself was a family. Lennie taught Bill Chase and myself at Berklee in 1955. I was supposedly at New England but ten blocks away was this Berklee School of Music and I wasn't allowed to go to because it didn't have a degree. My father being an academic in the Ivy League you know said, "No degree? You can't go there." So ten blocks away though was the Berklee School of Music and that's really where I was. Because they always needed trombone players. It was like a factory for big bands you know, they were all over the place. And so Chase and I learned to lock in on each other. As a lead player I'd be playing lead trombone, he'd be playing lead trumpet beautifully, just, you know, and he played lead trumpet beautifully largely because of Lennie Johnson's influence. Basie's band had the same thing he would go play lead with Basie's band and I played with Lennie at all of the Italian clubs around Boston and you know the big — Sinatra would come in and all that sort of stuff. So boy what we learned off Lennie. And he was a simple man who was extremely talented. He also went and played lead for Quincy Jones in that first Quincy Jones band that went overseas with Sarah Vaughan.

MR: Oh the Free and Easy Band.

PW: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. I know I have a picture of that, I'll have to look, yeah.

PW: Well I had two — I'll get some names wrong here — but that trumpet section they tell me was —

MR: Clark Terry was there.

PW: Clark Terry, Benny Bailey, Lennie Johnson, and Larry, another lead player. I think his first name was Larry. He was awesome. And then Floyd Standifer my dear friend. Floyd Standifer you've never heard of.

MR: No.

PW: Another educator out of Olympia, Washington. That's where he was raised. And he was with Quincy Jones's band and there's Clark and Benny and Lennie and X I can't come up with the name, and then Floyd Standifer and none of these guys knew Floyd Standifer. He said he had one solo a night. It was on the bridge of "Cherokee." And he said it took him eight bars to get it down to the microphone and eight bars —

MR: The things you don't learn in school.

PW: Right.

MR: Speaking of that, when you started there did you have free reign to establish a teaching method of your own pedagogy, whatever it was, was it up to you to decide?

PW: Yes.

MR: Good. Well I think that's the best a young person could hope for is to land with a person who just got off the road and who knew what the life was like and what was needed from musicians.

PW: Um hum. Teaching is a two-way street. Teaching is a two-way street. You know?

MR: Okay.

PW: A guy comes into your office and you say, "Well let's play a tune." And you know pretty much where he's at when within about 30 seconds. And you can recognize budding talent at all levels. I mean the level is huge. So once you've — I mean there's the one who hasn't a musical bone in his or her body but there are those and you kind of gently try to aim them in another direction. Then you have Makoto Ozone and Kirill Gerstein coming in at the age of twelve and you go oh my God is that unbelievable. And then you try to create an environment to have that person nurture his or her talent and that's what I did with Makoto Ozone who came in when he was twenty from — on an airplane from Japan knowing 50 English words and having a ticket for his first night in Boston at the Holiday Inn in Cambridge which is just about two miles from the airport. This was late at night and the cab driver took him 45 miles away to another Holiday Inn in Northbridge. Yeah. And left him there. I mean you could imagine. Boy. So the manager at the Holiday Inn in Northbridge recognized what had happened. Here's a guy who barely has no English, or 50 words is what he used to say. And there was a room which had a broken key or something like that and they let him stay free in that room overnight and then they arranged some sort of a ride back to Berklee. Son of a bitch, right? Sorry.

MR: Have you had experiences as time went on when some students might have come from really well established jazz programs in high school or perhaps they had teachers, and they would come to you and ask you about techniques or theory that was either foreign to you or that you didn't necessarily believe in, but they wanted to know about it?

PW: Well I would answer them with an inquiry if I had never heard of that approach I would ask to have the student explain what was involved. And I was trying to think of an example of that and I suppose — it wasn't Remington, Remington was a great teacher, no, no, no — Philadelphia — damn. There was a — I'll come up with it — I almost got it. There was a teacher in Philadelphia who taught the — oh damn it. You have a mouthpiece like this. You put it in your face and he would look for are you an upstream or are you a downstream. If you were an upstream that means when you went — as in playing a stream of air would come out of your horn and go upward and hit the top of the mouthpiece. And then there was the downstreamer. And I was a downstreamer.

Remington — it wasn't Remington damn it, I've almost got the name. And the pivot system. That's it. You could look up the word "pivot system" you'd have this guy's name. And there was a lot around the '70s, yeah, '70s — he was very popular. And there was a lot of people who believed that when you took the mouthpiece you should put it up in your face and find where it fits comfortably and live with it. And this guy had people moving it around a little like this, and he made it kind of a science, it was his thing. And I actually had him come up and do a lecture for us of which he was like the W.C. Fields type and he loved to be on stage with a cigar you know, the whole — he was on, of course Berklee was amazing. At one point in 1980 we had 80 trombone students. Now that's unbelievable. That was the high point. It's now somewhere around 20, 30.

MR: If one of your better students came to you, let's say they've done two years of a four year degree and they said, "I got an offer to go with Buddy Rich" what would you tell them?

PW: Go. Simple. Yep. Yep. That's the real thing you know.

MR: I imagine you've had those students or your colleagues did also, and some of them came back to finish and some of them didn't.

PW: Right. Well they went on to better days maybe in an area that they were working on. There aren't many Makotos in this world but there are a lot of people who have really good talent, fun to listen to, but the act isn't complete. Let's put it that way, for one reason or another. Maybe the individual wasn't that much into it or willing to deal with the realities of life as a traveling performer or something like that. Or sometimes they don't have the skills to play shows and things like that, so you try to steer, again the two way street. Teaching is a two-way street. As long as you've got that two-way street going you've got the world right there.

MR: I wanted to show you, I came across a program of a local high school band, this is in Central New York, the Whitesboro Jazz Ensemble concert, July 15, 1969. And the first piece on it — "Mercy Mercy Mercy" Joe Zawinul arranged by P. Wilson.

PW: Ta-da.

MR: Ta-da. You know that was like a hot chart and still is of course. And I remember playing it and I was and still am a huge Cannonball Adderley fan so when it got to that part in your arrangement where it abruptly changed keys I was like whoa — what was that?

PW: That was my first rock chart. And I'm sitting there — Buddy really wanted to do that. It was his doing. Cannonball had that album, the single rather, and it was kind of like a church scene if you remember. It was rumored — and I'm — he said that's the only — I wrote three in one week which is for me unheard of. But this was Buddy Rich and he was playing at Lennie's on the Turnpike, he's going to be there for one week, I better take advantage of the moment and come up with something. So I wrote "Chelsea Bridge" for him and I wrote "Mr. Lucky" [scats] from an old TV show. And I wrote "Mercy Mercy."

And the "Chelsea Bridge," that's right, "Lush Life," and "Mercy." And the last one — actually I wasn't used to the straight eighth notes at the time [scats] and writing all those damn things out, which takes some time. And so [scats] You know? And then there's that celebratory kind of sound, you know [scats].

MR: But why did you change keys? Just because you could?

PW: Yes. Boredom.

MR: Okay.

PW: This is going to be like four minutes in the key of B flat. It gives a little buzz but just move it up to D flat there for a minute. And then we kind of built it [scats] up a half step [scats] which is like that's from "My Fair Lady" that's from [scats] and home again, yeah.

MR: Were you there when they first read it?

PW: I sure was. At the end of the week they do the Sunday afternoon show, You know what that means, they'll play one set at 2. And I brought all the charts out. It was cold, it was one of those winter days. I had a long scarf around me and all that sort of thing and I knew I better have "Mercy" done. That's the only one that really mattered to him at that point. And the place, Lennie's on the Turnpike, Route 1 — I guess that would be Topsfield, and I walked into the door. The band is right here, all playing and he's over near the wall over there. And he just — he can see me coming in the door, the door's right there. The place is standing room only I mean it is packed, the Sunday session, right? And he yelled over, "You've got 'Mercy'?" I said, "Yeah." "Pass it out." And he passed it out. Yup. And I said, "You've got to be careful, there's a drum break for you that is one bar longer than you think. So you're going to have to think about that." And then two, three, four bang. Now you've got to remember I got many of those guys like Richie Cole and, you know, they were all friends of mine and had been with me with the Dues Band. So I got them on the band in the first place so they knew me and there was no problem there. And also I liked Buddy Rich. Buddy and I were friends and that was I guess my time sense is Buddy Rich's time sense. And it goes back to that stupid drumset that I had as a 10-year-old playing to Buddy Rich, of all things, Opus #1, "Sunny Side of the Street" and all those things that he did for Tommy. The time feel was all Buddy and that force has been with me. It still is. Makoto used to say to me, he said, "You know why we play so well together?" And I looked over and I said, "Yes I do." And he looked at me and we both said together, "Buddy Rich." We locked in. In fact Makoto and I toured around for about three years because of that record we made.

MR: What was the reaction to the first reading of "Mercy Mercy" at Lennie's on the Turnpike?

PW: Standing ovation.

MR: They stood for that, huh?

PW: Yup. I'm certainly going well I'll be damned. Yup. That's what happened.

MR: Wow.

PW: I've actually got a picture of me rehearsing his band. Of course I loved it. That's where I live.

MR: Well we've been at this for about an hour. I've got a couple of more questions. This one, I don't know if this is bad interviewing style but I know the answer to this but I'm going to ask you anyway.

PW: Okay.

MR: Are you familiar with the Billy May recording "Sort of Dixie"?

PW: Yes. I love it. Especially "South Rampart Street Parade." That son of a bitch is an absolute genius. You know it's the march [scats]. Right? And he's — this is high fidelity. We're not in stereo yet. Stereo did not exist when he recorded that. That is — the state of the art was high fidelity. You remember that. And he wrote that song so when you play it you can actually feel the parade going by you and continuing down the street. How did he pull that off?

MR: I sometimes wonder how the —

PW: That's a beautiful —

MR: That the musicians got through it without sort of cracking up sometimes. I mean it sounds like Spike Jones meets Sauter-Finegan or something.

PW: Absolutely. Spike Jones was, believe it or not my nickname at Phillips Exeter was "Spike" and it was because of Spike Jones. I had every Spike Jones record made ever. Oh man. I mean I even had a Spike Jones band with the — and I borrowed the pistol from the athletic department [scats]. [Sings] You always hurt/the one —

MR: Those guys could play though, man.

PW: Oh could they ever. I saw every Spike Jones — if there were two musicians I would be there at some point if they were within 200 miles of me, those two are Louis Armstrong and the other was Spike Jones. I went to — every year he would come and pack Symphony Hall which holds 4,500 people, two shows a day and it was the funniest stuff you ever heard. You know the things that I learned from Spike Jones is, as you said, those guys were some of the best musicians in the world. George Brock the trumpet player and I can't remember that drummer but the drummer was phenomenal. But they all were amazing. And the timing of all of the noises, the grunts and all, you know what I mean? It was dead on. Never miss. It was like listening to Buddy Rich.

MR: Yeah. It came off as spontaneous but was not. It was really arranged. What do you think, do you have an opinion if you observe what has happened to jazz education and its growth, I'm not sure I have a question here but I'm amazed at the level that jazz

education has risen to yet there seems to be a disconnect with record sales and just making a living as a jazz musician.

PW: I agree. You know the music is getting so fast. It reflects the society we live in today. I mean you can do everything instantly rather than develop an emotion. People don't have time. They don't want to wait for the story and the conclusion, they just want to hear the conclusion. Oh my God. And that really annoys me. And no wonder the sales are down. It's not communicating. Too many of these guys are playing the exercises. You know what I mean? [scats] "I bet I can play 'Giant Steps' faster than you."

MR: You can play it faster than me.

PW: You know that kind of stuff, that stuff pisses me off, really.

MR: Yeah. And my observation is, especially with the rhythm section players, is many people seem to be unsatisfied with just accompanying. It's almost like everybody's soloing at the same time.

PW: Absolutely. They are.

MR: Well we're showing our age —

PW: Yes.

MR: And our listening habits.

PW: Yes. Gee I read all the information on you when I heard we were going to be doing this, and your career actually is interesting 'cause boy, you're everywhere, you know in composition, classical so-called, but it's all music as far as I'm concerned, period. Right? Yeah I knew that.

MR: Well this has been marvelous. I know we could go on for a couple of more hours and maybe we'll look down the road for a part 2.

PW: It would be my pleasure.

MR: Yeah. I appreciate all your humor and mixed with wisdom, and I understand that your daughter was named after Marian McPartland, is that correct?

PW: Yes that is.

MR: And you spent some time —

PW: We worked a lot together. We were really very close.

MR: Yeah. She came, I invited her to play with my high school band at the time, and boy that is one classy person.

PW: Right.

MR: Yeah.

PW: That's why we were friends.

MR: You travel in good company.

PW: Right.

MR: Well Mr. Wilson, thank you again for your time. I'll pause the recording and we'll have a coda.

PW: Good.

MR: Okay.